CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



ON SORTING DUTY The plastic bazaar at Tikri Kalan in northwest Delhi

it's time to shift focus—plastic should be reserved for essential use in healthcare, defence and aerospace rather than for short-term, convenience-driven and single-use purposes.

Meanwhile, brand owners remain the biggest culprits in plastic pollution in the country, with packaging waste a significant contributor to the menace. According to a 2021 report titled 'Unwrapped: Exposing India's Top Plastic Polluters', by the global Movement #BreakFreeFromPlastic, multi-layered plastics—which are non-recyclable—made up 35 per cent of all plastic waste and 40 per cent of all branded plastic waste. Of the 149,985 pieces of plastic the researchers audited, Unilever, PepsiCo, Coca-Cola, Reckitt Benckiser, Nestlé, Amazon, Colgate-Palmolive, P&G, Kraft Heinz and Mondelez International emerged as the top global companies polluting India with plastic, while Parle, ITC, Britannia, Haldiram, United Spirits, Tata Consumer Products, Marico, Hector Beverages, Milky Mist and Balaji were among the Indian brands.



"ALMOST 30% OF OUR PLASTIC WASTE IS INCINERATED, AND IS INCLUDED IN THE RECYCLING FIGURES. THIS SHOULD NOT BE THE CASE"

SATISH SINHA
Associate Director, Toxics Link

Even when it comes to EPR, as Rodrigues of Saahas says, "Very few take up this responsibility at scale; even fewer do it in the right spirit." Cost is a constraint in formalising reverse logistics. "Brands don't want to pay appropriately for collection and recycling, and often opt for the informal sector," she says. The lack of standard guidelines on recycling complicates the situation further. Some 30-40 per cent of the waste leaks out solely because of